

FINAL PUSH
Left, PM Modi with state BJP chief Babulal Marandi at a rally in Garhwa, Nov. 4; CM Hemant Soren during a roadshow in Ranchi, Nov. 3

PTI

port from Muslims, who make up 14.5 per cent. Together, these two groups wield considerable influence in 45 seats across seven districts, with strong numbers in another 11. The Congress had a good support base among the Ho and Oraon communities, whereas the JMM enjoyed considerable backing from the Santhals. Recently, however, the Congress has been seen leaning heavily on the JMM's tribal support. In August, the Congress stepped up its efforts to court the Kurmi Mahto vote by appointing Keshav Mahto Kamlesh as the state party chief. The numerically significant Kurmi Mahtos are known to be traditional supporters of the BJP and the Sudesh Mahto-led All Jharkhand Students Union (AJSU).

The BJP has traditionally performed well in non-tribal and urban areas—that's what allowed it to hold on to 25 seats in the 2019 election, even as it slipped from 37 in 2014. But its near-wipeout in the 28 tribal seats showcased the asymmetry in its support base (and politics). Now, the party is hopeful that it can expand beyond its strongholds. The strategy is to consolidate urban and OBC-heavy areas while attempting to recover tribal seats lost to the JMM, which won a total of 30 seats in 2019, with the Congress securing 16.

The 2024 Lok Sabha poll outcome offers some encouragement for the BJP. Its alliance with the AJSU led in 50 of the state's 81 assembly segments, while the JMM, Congress and RJD were ahead in only 31. These shifts hint at a possible change in Jharkhand's political landscape, with both alliances vying to hold their ground amidst realigned strategies and evolving voter sentiments.

The final battle is under way—fought as much through the nitty gritty of alliances as through emotion from town halls to the homes and fields of the Adivasi heartland. Here, cradling a baby, sharing a simple meal of *chuda* with a group of women in a tidy Adivasi home, and engaging in face-to-face conversations hold more value than a WhatsApp message or a YouTube clip. This is why the 46-year-old first-time candidate, Meera Munda, strives to visit every home. Fluent in Bengali—a language spoken by the tribal communities in these parts, just 60 km away from West Bengal—Meera actively bridges cultures and communities, giving her campaign a personal touch. Around election time, it's a crowded market, though. ■

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